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GLOBAL WAR ON TERROR... A FAILURE!

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The War on Terror is in peril

The world needs to be united on the issue of terrorism and resolve contradictions



The brutal attack on Easter Sunday in Sri Lanka, for which the Islamic State (IS) claimed responsibility, has reignited discussion on the global 'War on Terror'. Scholars and officials across the world are studying the link of the bombers to the IS's former 'Caliphate' in Syria, where at least two of the bombers are believed to have travelled, and several leaders have been called for a greater focus on the global dimensions of the counter-terrorism effort. The attack in Sri Lanka, however, also underlines the many cracks in the concept of a global 'War on Terror', and raise questions on what it has achieved in the time since the term was coined by former U.S. President George W. Bush after the September 11 attacks in 2001.

A broadening war

First, the original mission that the war on 'terror' was named for is broadening. Not only has the coalition of almost 80 countries that were troops and offered logistical support for Operation Enduring Freedom failed to end terrorism in Afghanistan, it appears it is preparing to fund the country back to the oppressive Taliban regime that it defeated in December 2001. This, despite the fact there is no guarantee that the same groups bring in safe havens in Pakistan will not also have the run of Afghanistan once the coalition pulls out.

The war in Afghanistan was only one of the many conditions the U.S. laid in the name of the War on Terror. It continues joined the coalition of the willing to defeat Saddam Hussein in Iraq in 2003, and IS was a part of the coalition that ousted Muammar Gaddafi from power in Libya in 2011. The U.S. and allied countries were also distracted by the 'Arab Spring' in 2011, which had them to rethink their policy in the Middle East. This eventually paved the way for the rise of IS, which has been called a 'Caliphate' in Iraq and Syria. The next coalition was formed to fight the terror of the



The attack in Sri Lanka underlines the many cracks in the concept of a global 'War on Terror'. Security personnel inspect the interior of St. Sebastian's Church in Negombo, Sri Lanka, on April 22, a day after the Easter Sunday blasts.

IS. The number of global terror attacks mentioned in a Global Terrorism Database by the University of Maryland, of events from 2001 to 2016 per year went up from 1,000 to 2,000. In 2016, the number of attacks in Sri Lanka was 1,000. It is clear that the countries in question - Afghanistan, Syria, Libya and Iraq - are far from free of the spectre of terrorism. Despite the defeat of the 'Caliphate' in Iraq and Syria, the IS or its franchises are appearing in new parts of the world. Sri Lanka is no exception in this.

Second, rather than bringing light to the issue of terrorism, the War on Terror appears to have the IS and al-Qaeda more, giving them a last gasp for bigger than their actual ability. This helps them recruit and radicalise Muslim youth from around the globe, and allows them to gain terrorism around the world as their own. As IS leader Abu Bakr al-Baghdadi did in a rare video posted shortly after the Easter Sunday attack.

Not a 'fight for Islam'

Third, the narrative they build of a 'fight for Islam' is equally false. According to the Global Terrorism Database, of the 30 terror attacks in which more than 100 were killed (high casualty) since 2001, more than 70 were carried out in Islamic or Muslim majority countries. In a specific search of high casualty or not attacks on religious institutions since 2001, 11 of the top 20 were by Islamic groups in mosques. The War on Terror thus appears to be a

concept peddled mostly by jihadists and groups and propagated most of its by extremists of other religions as a motive for terror attacks, such as the 2011 Norway island attack in Norway or the New Zealand attack in New Zealand. Governments to countries of which by terrorism must not subscribe to this narrative blindly.

In Sri Lanka, for example, the reason the members of the National Therothel Jatharath (NTJ) were arrested in their district of Jaffna had as much to do with the fact that intelligence agencies given by India were in need as it did with the fact that once the defeat of the LTTE, Sri Lankan authorities had let their guard down and ignored growing internal threats. As a result, despite complaints about the speeches that suspected members of the National Therothel Jatharath made in a province of a mosque in Sri Lanka's Eastern province, he was unchanged. Police and intelligence agencies also failed to keep a close eye on other NTJ members who were IS recruits, despite the fact that only about 12 Sri Lankans in all are believed to have travelled to IS territory.

Approaches to fighting terror

Fourth, it is necessary for countries fighting terrorism to learn more about the groups, their differences, rather than try to generalize from experience. Comparing European states like the U.S., France and Belgium, where hundreds of immigrants have been radicalized for the IS, to South

Asian states like India, where Muslim populations are indigenous and only a few dozen are believed to have left for Syria, is also to compare apples and oranges. Indian officials have also claimed a higher success in defeating IS terrorists, because they have reduced whole families, neighbourhoods and local Muslims to their efforts. In Bangladesh too, after the 2016 attack on the Dhaka Arts and Culture Centre, government advertisements asked citizens to check on their children's activities. This acknowledgment that radicalised terrorists are a part of a community is in stark contrast to the current debate in many European countries that are refusing to take IS concerns and their families back. Similarly, several Central Asian states propagate a much more hard-line approach to counter radicalisation, by banning beards and hijabs, while China's re-education camps have raised questions about human rights. The success or failure of such of these approaches must be studied before deciding their applicability elsewhere.

Fifth, the world community must address contradictions in the War on Terror. For 20 years, the world has failed to agree on a common definition of terrorism at the United Nations. This has held up the passage of the Indian government proposed for a Cooperative Commonwealth International Terrorism. Despite the fact that Jack-a-Mohammed chief Ma-mad al-Bashir has been targeted by India for years, they must ask why China allowed its IS security Council designation in a global terrorist only after mentions of his attacks in India were removed. They must ask why the U.S. is focused on killing but the 'world's biggest state sponsor of terrorism', while states like Saudi Arabia and Pakistan that have funded and still fund Islamic terrorist groups are still treated as 'non-state actors' on terror. And why, despite all their resources and expertise, the alliance of the U.S., the U.K., Canada, Australia and New Zealand that does global intelligence was unable to see the impending threat in Sri Lanka. Unless the world is truly united on the issue and resolves such contradictions, the global War on Terror will only be as strong as its weakest link.

Author: Rajiv Kumar

UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II ... International Relations

Effect of policies and politics of developed and developing countries on India's interests, Indian diaspora.

DRAFT QUESTION

During the past two decades "Global War on Terror" by the advanced nations is further destabilizing the countries. Do you agree? Elaborate your answer with specific examples.

52 The War on Terror is in peril

The world needs to be united on the issue of terrorism and resolve contradictions

The brutal attacks on Easter Sunday in Sri Lanka, for which the Islamic State (IS) claimed responsibility, have reignited discussion on the global 'War on Terror'. Scholars and officials across the world are studying the links of the bombers to the IS's former 'Caliphate' in Syria, where at least two of the bombers are believed to have travelled, and several leaders have now called for a greater focus on the global dimensions of the counter-terrorism effort. The attacks in Sri Lanka, however, also underline the many cracks in the concept of a global 'War on Terror', and raise questions on what it has achieved in the time since the term was coined by former U.S. President George W. Bush after the September 11 attacks in 2001.

A floundering war

First, the original mission that the War on Terror was named for is floundering. Not only has the coalition of about 60 countries that sent troops and offered logistical support for 'Operation Enduring Freedom' failed to end terrorism in Afghanistan, it appears it is preparing to hand the country back to the oppressive Taliban regime that it defeated in December 2001. This, despite the fact there is no guarantee that the terror groups living in safe havens in Pakistan will not also have the run of Afghanistan once the coalition pulls out.

The war in Afghanistan was only one of the many coalitions the U.S. led in the name of the War on Terror: 46 nations joined the 'coalition of the willing' to defeat Saddam Hussein in Iraq in 2003, and 19 were a part of the coalition that ousted Muammar Qaddafi from power in Libya in 2011. The U.S. and allied countries were sidetracked by the 'Arab Spring' in 2011, which led them to bolster anti-Bashar al-Assad groups in Syria. This eventually paved the way for the IS to establish a 'Caliphate' in territories in Syria and Iraq.

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The next coalition was formed to fight the terror of the IS. The number of global terror attacks (maintained in a Global Terrorism Database by the University of Maryland of events from 1970 to 2018) per year went up from 1,000 in 2004 to 17,000 in 2014. It is clear that the countries in question — Afghanistan, Syria, Libya and Iraq — are far from free of the spectre of terrorism. Despite the defeat of the 'Caliphate' territorially, the IS or its franchises are appearing in new parts of the world. Sri Lanka is the latest on that list.

Second, rather than helping fight pan-Islamist terror groups, the War on Terror appears to help the IS and al-Qaeda more, giving them a footprint far bigger than their actual abilities. This helps them recruit and radicalise Muslim youth from around the globe, and allows them to own terrorists around the world as their own, as IS leader Abu Bakr al-Baghdadi did in a rare video posted shortly after the Easter Sunday attacks.

Not a 'fight for Islam'

Third, the narrative they build of a "fight for Islam" is equally false. According to the Global Terrorism Database, of the 81 terror attacks in which more than 100 were killed (high casualty) since 2001, more than 70 were carried out in Islamic or Muslim-majority countries. In a specific search of high casualty terror attacks on religious institutions since 2001, 18 of the top 20 were by Islamist groups on mosques. The War on Terror thus appears to be a concept peddled mostly by pan-Islamist groups and propagated most often by extremists of other religions as a motive for terror attacks, such as the 2011 Utoya island attack in Norway or the New Zealand attacks this year. Governments in countries affected by terrorism must not subscribe to this narrative blindly.

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In Sri Lanka, for example, the reason the members of the National Thowheed Jamaath (NTJ) were successful in their diabolical plot had as much to do with the fact that intelligence inputs given by India were ignored as it did with the fact that since the defeat of the LTTE, Sri Lankan authorities had let their guard down and ignored growing internal fault lines. As a result, despite complaints about the speeches that suspected mastermind Mohamed Zahran Hashim made as a preacher of a mosque in Sri Lanka's Eastern province, he went unchallenged. Police and intelligence agencies also failed to keep a stern eye on other NTJ bombers who were IS returnees, despite the fact that only about 32 Sri Lankans in all are believed to have travelled to IS territory.

Approaches to fighting terror

Fourth, it is necessary for countries fighting terrorism to learn more closely from their differences, rather than try to generalise from experience. Comparing European states like the U.K., France and Belgium, where hundreds of immigrant Muslims have enlisted for the IS, to South Asian states like India, where Muslim populations are indigenous and only a few dozen are believed to have left for Syria, is akin to comparing apples and oranges. Indian officials have also claimed a higher success in deradicalising IS returnees, because they have enlisted whole families, neighbourhoods and local Maulvis in their efforts. In Bangladesh too, after the 2016 attack on the Holey Artisan Bakery, government advertisements asked mothers to check on their children's activities. This acknowledgement that radicalised terrorists are a part of a community is in stark contrast to the current debate in many European countries that are refusing to take IS returnees and their families back. Similarly, several Central Asian states propagate a much more hard-line approach on counter-radicalisation, by banning beards and hijabs, while China's re-education internment camps in Xinjiang have raised questions about human rights. The success or failure of each of these approaches must be studied before deciding their applicability elsewhere.

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Fifth, the world community must address contradictions in the War on Terror. For 20 years, the world has failed to agree on a common definition of terrorism at the United Nations. This has held up the passage of the Indian-sponsored proposal for a Comprehensive Convention on International Terrorism. Despite the fact that Jaish-e-Mohammad chief Masood Azhar has been targeting Indians incessantly for years, they must ask why China allowed his UN Security Council designation as a global terrorist only after mentions of his attacks in India were removed. They must ask why the U.S. is focused on billing Iran the “world’s biggest state sponsor of terrorism”, while states like Saudi Arabia and Pakistan that have funded and sheltered Islamist terror groups are still treated as “frontline allies” on terror. And why, despite all their resources and expertise, the alliance of the U.S., the U.K., Canada, Australia and New Zealand that share global intelligence was unable to see the impending threat in Sri Lanka. Unless the world is truly united on the issue and resolves such contradictions, the global War on Terror will only be as strong as its weakest link.

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FAILURES OF WAR ON TERROR!

1

AFGHANISTAN ISSUE



- Coalition of about 60 countries that sent troops and offered logistical support for '**Operation Enduring Freedom**' failed to end terrorism in Afghanistan.
- It appears, USA is preparing to hand over the country back to the oppressive Taliban regime that it defeated in December, 2001.
- There is every possibility once the coalition pulls out, terror groups living in safe havens in Pakistan may have a free run in Afghanistan.

FAILURES OF WAR ON TERROR!

2

IRAQ ISSUE

Iraq



- 46 nations joined the '**coalition of the willing**', to defeat Saddam Hussein in Iraq in 2003.
- Subsequently, the country is into chaos and Islamic State destabilised Iraq further.

FAILURES OF WAR ON TERROR!

3

LIBYA ISSUE



ALGERIA

LIBYA

EGYPT

SUDAN

CHAD

CENTRAL
AFRICAN
REPUBLIC

SOUTH SUDAN

ETHIOPIA

SAUDI ARABIA

YEMEN

ERITREA

Red Sea

Persian Gulf

IRAN

IRAQ

SYRIA

JORDAN

TURKEY

Greece

SPAIN

PORTUGAL

IVORY COAST

Ghana

- 19 Countries were part of the coalition that ousted Muammar Gaddafi from power in Libya in 2011.
- The country even after 8 years is reeling under sectarian violence.
- The condition of civic infrastructure gone down badly.

FAILURES OF WAR ON TERROR!

RUSSIA

4

SYRIA ISSUE

SYRIA

IRAQ



- The U.S. and Allied Countries supported anti-Bashar al-Assad groups in Syria.
- Subsequently anarchy prevailed and the country divided on sectarian lines.
- This paved the way for the IS to establish a 'Caliphate' in territories in Iraq and Syria.
- This led to millions of refugees towards Turkey and beyond.

THE FALL-OUT OF 'WAR ON TERROR'



- Rather than helping fight pan-Islamist terror groups, the War on Terror appears to help the IS and Al-Qaeda more, giving them a footprint far bigger than their actual abilities.
- This helps them recruit and radicalise Muslim youth from around the Globe.
- It allows them to own terrorists around the World as their own, as IS leader Abu Bakr al-Baghdadi did in a rare video posted shortly after the Easter Sunday attacks.



SEE THE INCREASE!

- The number of global terror attacks maintained in a Global Terrorism Database by the University of Maryland went up from 1,000 in 2004 to 17,000 in 2014.
- Since 2001, 18 of the top 20 were by Islamist groups on mosques.

5 Despite all their resources and expertise, the alliance of the U.S., the U.K., Canada, Australia and New Zealand that share global intelligence, was unable to see the threat in Sri Lanka.

4 Why the U.S. is focusing on Iran by calling it “world’s biggest state sponsor of terrorism”, while states like Saudi Arabia and Pakistan that have funded and sheltered Islamist terror groups are still treated as “frontline allies”.



**TERRORISM ...
BIGGER THAN
ANTICIPATED!**



1 For 20 years, the world has failed to agree on a common definition of terrorism at the United Nations.

2 This held up the passage of the Indian-sponsored proposal for a Comprehensive Convention on International Terrorism

3 Despite the fact that, Masood Azhar is targeting Indians incessantly for years. It is not clear why China allowed his UN Security Council designation, only after mention of his attacks in India were removed.

Unless the World is truly united on the issue and resolves such contradictions, the Global War on Terror may not see the desired result. Moreover, it may destabilize the Countries!

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SINCERE THANKS
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